

The Pintail Experience

Deep-Dive Market Research

May 2026

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Pintail Experiences — Deep-Dive Market Research

Prepared May 21, 2026 — for the founders of Pintail Experiences and the team supporting them. Built from five parallel research streams covering hunter demographics, the premium outfitter industry, the faith-based retreat ecosystem, the corporate/executive retreat market, and the software/platform landscape. All numbers are sourced inline; consolidated source list at the bottom.

How to use this doc. This is the long-term market context — the why-this-business-works case. Pricing benchmarks, competitive whitespace, channel options, sourced data points. **Immediate execution is in the Action Plan**, which is focused entirely on landing the Dec 30 inaugural trip well. Treat the strategic recommendations here as the playbook for what becomes relevant after Trip 1 succeeds. The data is durable; the priorities sequence over time.

Executive Summary

The opportunity for Pintail Experiences is real, sized, and structurally underserved. Five top-line findings shape everything below.

One — The whitespace is genuine. Three industries (premium wingshooting, faith-based men’s discipleship, transformational/experiential corporate retreats) are each large and growing on their own, but no operator stacks all three. The closest analogues — Wild at Heart on the faith/curriculum side, Pine Hill Plantation on the hunting side, Brush Creek Ranch on the corporate-experiential side, C12 on the Christian-CEO side — each address only one or two of the three. Pintail’s “premium hunt + intentional faith curriculum + production value” position is structurally empty.

Two — The market is large. 14.4 million U.S. hunters in 2022; an estimated 1.4–2.2 million with HHI \$150K+; the corporate retreats market is \$31.8B in 2024 growing to \$73.7B by 2034 (9.1% CAGR); wellness/transformational travel is a \$1T+ category with 30–40% premium willingness-to-pay vs. equivalent non-transformational experiences. Even capturing 0.1% of the affluent-hunter slice produces a healthy lifestyle business; capturing a sliver of the corporate-retreat budget puts Pintail in eight figures.

Three — Pricing has substantial headroom. Premium quail and duck lodges already charge \$1,000–\$2,250 per person per day with no curriculum and no faith framing. Pintail can defensibly anchor at \$5,000–\$8,500 for a 3-day retreat and \$10,000–\$12,000 for a 5-day flagship, with a \$25K–\$50K annual “corporate membership” tier that mirrors C12’s recurring-revenue model. None of these prices require Pintail to invent willingness-to-pay — every band is already validated by an adjacent competitor.

Four — Don’t own the lodge. Be the curator. The lodge layer is fragmented, mom-and-pop, and partner-friendly. Land economics in the Red Hills make new ownership prohibitive (Longpine Plantation sold for \$28M in 2015; Wynfield went private in 2025). The right move is asset-light: build the brand and the experience platform on top of an Orvis-Endorsed / Beretta Trident-tier partner network.

Five — Buy software in Year 1, build in Year 2+. A stitched stack of WeTravel + HubSpot/Pipedrive + Airtable/Softpwr runs ~\$4K/year and ships in 2–4 weeks. The custom CRM/ERP/portal becomes the moat only after the experience itself is repeatable and growth is software-limited — likely by Trip #15–25. Spending \$40K on custom software before then will largely be thrown away.

The rest of this document is the evidence, the competitive map, and the strategy that flows from these five findings.

1. The Hunter Market — Size, Spend, Geography, Demographics

Total hunters and trend

Per the USFWS 2022 National Survey of Fishing, Hunting, and Wildlife-Associated Recreation, there were **14.4 million U.S. residents age 16+ hunting in 2022** — about 6% of the adult population. That number reflects a partial COVID-era rebound from 11.5 million in 2016, but sits well below the early-1990s peak of ~17 million. License-sales tracking (CAHSS) shows a ~5% surge in 2020, -1.9% in 2021, -3.1% in 2022, and -0.3% in 2023. The pandemic surge largely did not stick, but the floor has stabilized.

Spending behavior

Hunters spent **\$45.2 billion in 2022**, broken down as: equipment \$19.6B (43%), trip-related expenses \$12.3B (27%), licenses \$1B+, and “other” the balance. Average per-hunter annual spend is \$837; per-day-in-field spend is \$51. Those are sport-wide averages. The destination/guided slice is dramatically more expensive — see Section 2.

The affluent slice

About 23% of high-income Americans participate in hunting or fishing (Statista 2023). If even 10-15% of the 14.4M hunter base has HHI \$150K+, that is **1.4-2.2 million affluent hunters** — Pintail’s realistic top-of-funnel. A 0.1% annual capture rate at a \$4,000 average selling price produces \$5.6M-\$8.8M in revenue.

Waterfowl and upland slices

- **Waterfowl.** Federal Duck Stamps sell ~1.5 million units per year and have been stable since the 2015 price increase. Ducks Unlimited reported \$333M in FY24 revenue, 678,000 members, and 5,200 fundraising events drawing 629,000 attendees. Delta Waterfowl is smaller (~94 employees, 5,500 volunteers). Arkansas alone has 100,000+ waterfowl hunters. The Mississippi Flyway accounts for ~40% of all North American ducks and geese.
- **Upland.** Bobwhite quail populations are down 82-85% over the last 40-50 years — wild-bird hunting is functionally extinct in much of the historic range, which has driven the migration to commercial plantation/preserve hunting in Georgia, Florida, Texas, the Carolinas, and Alabama. Pheasants Forever + Quail Forever combined have ~700 chapters, 750+ annual banquets, and ~140,000 members.

Demographics

- **Gender.** Female participation doubled from 9% (2001) to ~22% (2022), and 33% of new hunters are female. Fastest-growing segment per NSSF.
- **Age.** Median hunter is approximately 47. The 65+ share is rising ~5%/year; the 6-12 share is rising ~3%/year. The middle is thinning — a barbell pattern with implications for product mix (father-son and father-daughter trips ride both ends of the curve).
- **Income.** ~45% of hunters earn \$50K-\$100K HHI; the upper tail is disproportionately represented in guided/destination spend.
- **Geography.** Highest per-capita: Maine (15.6%), Wisconsin (11.3%), Vermont (9.7%), Minnesota (9.5%). Raw numbers concentrate in the Deep South, Plains, and Upper Midwest. For Pintail's faith-aligned positioning, the densest overlap of hunter participation and Christian/evangelical identification is the South + Plains corridor: TX, GA, AR, TN, SC, NC, AL, OK, MO, KY.

The cultural moment

The “Yellowstone / MeatEater / Yeti” macro trend is a 10-year boom in *performative authenticity* — affluent professionals paying premium for genuine rural and outdoor identity. Specifics:

- **Yeti Holdings** — ~\$1.95B revenue in 2025, growth driven by premium positioning into hunting/fishing/outdoor lifestyle.
- **MeatEater (Steven Rinella)** — lifestyle media + commerce, ~\$100M+ revenue, has acquired First Lite (2019), FHF Gear, Phelps Game Calls, and Dave Smith Decoys; opened flagship retail in Bozeman (2024) and Wisconsin (2025).
- **Yellowstone (Paramount)** — most-watched scripted cable show in U.S. history at peak; multiple spinoffs (1883, 1923) keep the cultural air saturated with rural-Western aesthetic.

The combined signal: affluent suburbanites *want* to buy rural/outdoor experience. Pintail's job is to be the faith-aligned, family-grounded version of that purchase.

Why this matters for Pintail

The TAM is large enough to support a strong lifestyle business at a 0.1% capture rate and a serious growth business at 0.5-1%. The geography of the customer overlaps cleanly with the geography of the product (Southern plantation belt, Mississippi Flyway). And the cultural moment is doing the brand-building heavy lifting for free.

2. The Premium Hunting Outfitter Industry — Players, Pricing, Structure

Industry size and shape

IBISWorld pegs U.S. Hunting & Trapping at **\$1.2B in revenue across ~17,600 businesses** (2025/26), growing at a 3.7% CAGR. The premium/luxury slice grows faster on the back of corporate-entertainment recovery. The industry is *extremely fragmented* — there is no Marriott of hunting lodges. Operators are predominantly multi-generational independent family-owned plantations, validated not by chain ownership but by endorsement networks: **Orvis Endorsed Wingshooting Lodges** (~28 lodges, 11 states); **Beretta Trident** (only 4 North American lodges — Pine Hill, Joshua Creek, Cheyenne Ridge SD, Highland Hills OR — fewer than 5% of global destinations qualify); Shooting Sportsman Endorsed; Wingshooting Destinations directory. PE consolidation at the operating-lodge layer is essentially absent.

Top quail destinations and pricing

The iconic U.S. quail belt is the **Red Hills region** between Thomasville GA and Tallahassee FL (436,000 acres of long-leaf pine, the densest bobwhite habitat in the country), extending west to Albany GA. Secondary corridor: South/West Texas, Oklahoma, Kansas. Confirmed 2025/26 pricing per person:

Lodge	Location	Pricing	Notes
Riverview Plantation	Camilla, GA	\$1,555/day all-in (hunt \$995 + lodging \$315 + meals \$245)	12-quail bag, dogs, Jeep, single occupancy. Books 1-2 years out.
Pine Hill Plantation	Donalsonville, GA	\$6,800/person for a 3 hunt day / 4 night event (Super Bowl 2026); custom quotes for private groups 4-28	Only lodge that is both Orvis Endorsed AND Beretta Trident. Horseback/mule-wagon hunts.
Wynfield Plantation	Albany, GA	Historical \$350-\$775/day	Closed to public in 2025 — sold to private buyer after 21 years.

Lodge	Location	Pricing	Notes
Rio Piedra Plantation	Camilla, GA	All-inclusive double occupancy, custom quote	3 meals, full bar, hors d'oeuvres, lodging. Oct 17 - Mar 22 season.
Joshua Creek Ranch	Boerne, TX	\$3,750-\$4,250/shooter for 2N/2D wingshooting; custom packages	Orvis Endorsed + Beretta Trident — the only TX lodge with Trident.
Greystone Castle	Mingus, TX	\$2,250/hunt, max 3 guns/truck	Unlimited birds, lodging, gourmet meals, clays, dogs, processing.
Pursell Farms / Orvis Shooting Grounds	Sylacauga, AL	\$615/full-day quail + \$60 guest fee	Orvis-branded experience, 3,000 acres near Birmingham.
SouthWind Plantation	Attapulcus, GA	Custom (Orvis Lodge of the Year)	4 lodges, ~35-guest capacity, top corporate venue.

Top duck destinations and pricing

The waterfowl spine runs through the Mississippi Flyway (Stuttgart AR, Reelfoot Lake TN, Missouri's Golden Triangle) and the Pacific Flyway (Sacramento Valley CA), with hotspots on the Texas Gulf Coast, Louisiana marshes, Chesapeake Bay, and Northern Plains.

Operator	Location	Pricing
Five Oaks Duck Lodge	Humphrey, AR	Pricing on application; small groups ≤ 12 , 6,000 acres flooded timber/rice, since 1983.
Habitat Flats	Sumner, MO + Saskatchewan	\$2,100-\$2,300 per 3 days at Home Lodge; \$2,000/day at The Grand. Includes 5-star meals, lodging, beer/wine.

Operator	Location	Pricing
Black Dog Hunting Club	Stuttgart, AR	\$1,150 for 2 days (lodging, meals, hunts) ≈ \$575/day.
Ducks-n-Dogs	Stuttgart, AR	\$600/person/day inclusive of lodging, meals, processing.
Dirty Delta Outfitters	AR	\$1,250 for 2 days; \$650/day additional.
Reelfoot Lake operators	TN	\$300-\$625/day; lodge-inclusive at top end.
Sacramento Valley operators	CA	\$300-\$400/day; lodging typically not included.

Sacramento Valley pricing skews lower because most CA hunts are guide-only. Arkansas/Missouri lodge-inclusive is the genre's premium standard.

What “premium” actually means in this segment

Beyond shooting access, the consistent benchmarks across Riverview, Pine Hill, Rio Piedra, Joshua Creek, SouthWind, Habitat Flats, and Brush Creek Ranch:

- Single-occupancy private rooms; master suites 1,000+ sq ft at the top end
- Chef-prepared meals, regional/Southern signature recipes, full bar, wine pairings, hors d'oeuvres pre-dinner
- Specially-equipped Jeeps or horseback/mule-wagon in-field; private airstrips at some properties; airport transfers
- Pre-hunt warm-up clays, certified Orvis instructors, gun rentals, ammo, professional dog kennels
- 1:2 or 1:3 guide ratio; hunt masters + wagon drivers + assistants at private group level
- Bird cleaning/vacuum-packing free; cigars/bourbon evenings; sporting clays courses; spa at some
- Orvis Endorsement and/or Beretta Trident as de facto Michelin stars

Business model norms

Industry sources put gross margins above 80% on hunts, with net margins (after F&B, labor, overhead) settling around 30%. Seasonality is extreme: quail mid-Oct-late March; duck Oct-Jan. **~60% of annual high-value bookings fall in Q4-Q1.** Guides

may only be billable ~4 months/year, forcing fixed-cost discipline and shoulder-season programming (sporting clays, dove, weddings, corporate events).

Capacity is the binding constraint — premium plantations have 12–35 bed capacity. Pine Hill caps private groups at 28; SouthWind ~35; Five Oaks ~12. Top lodges book **1–2 years out**. Client sourcing leans on (1) Orvis Endorsed program as discovery funnel, (2) referral/repeat (industry rule of thumb: 60–80% repeat rates), (3) Frontiers Travel, Shooting Sportsman magazine, Kevin’s Catalog as boutique sales channels, (4) corporate sales reps and Fortune 500 entertainment-buyer relationships.

A 3-day all-inclusive benchmark

Stacking the data: a premium 3-day all-inclusive trip at a top-tier wingshooting lodge typically falls in the **\$4,500–\$7,500 per person** range. Pine Hill’s \$6,800 Super Bowl event is the clean ultra-premium benchmark. Greystone’s typical 3-day at \$2,250/day lands at ~\$6,750. A 5-day trip at a Beretta Trident-tier lodge realistically runs **\$8,000–\$12,000 per person** once gratuity, transport, and license are layered on.

Trends

- Premium hunting tourism is growing slowly (3.7% sport-wide CAGR) but the corporate-entertainment slice is recovering and growing faster.
- Land economics in the Red Hills are under stress (Longpine Plantation sold for \$28M in 2015 at \$4,800/acre, well above ag-only pricing). New entrants at the operator/owner level can’t make the numbers work — which is why the top operators are decades old, and why Wynfield went private in 2025.
- Endorsement scarcity is structural: only 28 Orvis Endorsed lodges and 4 North American Beretta Trident lodges. Validated supply is constrained.

Why this matters for Pintail

Three implications. **(1)** Don’t try to own a lodge — the lodge layer is fragmented and partner-friendly; Pintail’s value-add is curation, brand, and faith framing, not real estate. **(2)** Anchor partnerships in the Red Hills (Rio Piedra, Pine Hill, SouthWind, Riverview) and the Stuttgart-Missouri Golden Triangle (Habitat Flats, Five Oaks, Black Dog) plus Joshua Creek for TX geographic spread. **(3)** Price at parity with Pine Hill’s \$6,800 3-day event and Greystone’s \$6,750 — that gives room to layer faith programming, branded gear, and production value premium without pricing above the genre.

3. The Faith-Based Retreat Landscape — Where the Curriculum Validation Comes From

This is the most strategically informative of the five research streams, because it shows both the demand validation Pintail needs and the precise gap it can fill.

Christian hunting ministries — the donor-subsidized floor

The faith-and-hunting space is dominated by **501(c)(3) ministries delivering single-day events or short retreats**, donor-supported and volunteer-staffed. The major players:

- **Fellowship of Christian Sportsmen / FCS Plus** (TX, 1988)
- **Christian Outdoor Fellowship of America (COFA)** — uses outdoors as evangelism tool
- **Sportpersons Ministries** — helps churches host outdoor events
- **CamoChristians / Sportsmen for Christ, Sportsmen for God, Trinity Sportsman Ministry, Sportsmen Fellowship Ministries (PA)** — regional 501(c)(3)s, mostly archery/youth-oriented
- **The Greatest Hunt (GHCOF)** — content/curriculum ministry built on “sin = missing the mark” archery metaphor
- **FCA Outdoors** — Fellowship of Christian Athletes’ outdoor arm; volunteer-led regional huddles, fishing tournaments, hunts, youth camps
- **Blast & Cast Men’s Ministries, Legacy Outdoor Ministries**
- **Refreshed Soul** — the closest analog to a premium model: 5-day pastor hunting retreats with lodging, meals, curriculum. Donor-funded — they cover ~2/3 of cost and ask the church to fund 1/3. Pastor-only audience.
- **Ironman Outdoor Ministries** — runs 40+ men’s outdoor weekend retreats per year across 12 states
- **Peterson Outdoors** — operates Lodge of Hope
- **Real Momentum / “Pastors in the Outdoors”** — pastor-family focused

Pricing range: \$0-\$300 per person for the volunteer-led tier; \$500-\$650/day for the faith-branded hunting lodges that exist (Heaven Scent Retreat in GA, Beatrice Hunter’s Retreat in AL); ~\$1,950 all-in for a 3-day at Heaven Scent.

Faith-branded for-profit hunting lodges also exist (Honey Brake in LA, Heaven Scent, Woods-N-Water in GA) but they are *for-profit lodges with faith branding, not structured discipleship retreats*. The faith element is a marketing layer, not a curriculum.

Wild at Heart — the cultural proof point

This is the single most important comp for Pintail’s curriculum thesis. John Eldredge’s *Wild at Heart* has sold **~5 million copies since 2001** and still moves >100,000 copies a year. The Boot Camp model — a 3-night retreat at \$245–\$260 per person all-in (lodging + meals + materials) — is run only **2-3 times a year by the official org**, with the rest of demand met by **independent licensed/affiliated events (“Allies,” “BASIC”) run by local churches**.

What makes it work: rich masculine vocabulary the broader Christian church had lost; physical setting in Colorado mountains rather than a church basement; tight 3-day arc with confrontation/breakthrough structure; franchise-by-permission model that lets churches scale it.

What its limitation is: it is essentially a teaching retreat with hiking. There is no real adventure component, no premium production value, no executive-grade hospitality.

The implication for Pintail: demand for premium masculine Christian experience clearly exists (5M books, demand exceeds the 2–3 events/year supply). The hunting/quail/waterfowl world is empty above the camp-meeting price tier. Pintail is the Wild at Heart that says yes 20 weekends a year with consistent quality.

Father-son and family discipleship

The most fragmented segment. Operators include Fathers in the Field (mentor-boy pairings + 4 outings/month + year-end rite of passage), Discipleship Adventures (father/son and father/daughter outdoor events), Hume Christian Camps’ Father-Son Adventure Camps, REALMAN (3GEN Ministries) curriculum, Christian Service Brigade “Tree Climbers,” Primal Path subscription, Manhood Journey curriculum, and Legacy Outdoor Ministries. **Nobody is running premium (\$2K–\$5K) curated father-son or father-daughter hunting retreats with theological curriculum at scale.** Whitespace.

Christian CEO peer-advisory — the corporate channel that already exists

Three networks dominate the Christian CEO peer space, and none of them sell premium outdoor retreats as a core product. They are channel partners, not competitors.

- **C12 Group** — founded 1992, ~4,300 members across ~200 chairs in US/global, **\$875–\$1,200/month** depending on company revenue. Monthly forums, biennial national conference. **Total membership revenue ~\$50M+/year of pre-qualified Christian CEOs.**
- **Convene** — Christian CEO peer team model; \$1M+ revenue floor for entry, \$2M+ for mature tier; pricing custom. 2.5-day national conference; annual team retreats are a member benefit, not core.

- **Truth at Work** — Christian executive roundtables; monthly format; pricing locally negotiated.
- **Halftime Institute** — 12-month Fellows Program at **\$6,000** including 4 facilitated meetings + 12 coaching sessions. Validates the willingness-to-pay for transformational Christian content.
- **Pinnacle Forum** — 501(c)(3) Christian peer forums; weekly meetings.

A Pintail “C12 Chapter Annual Retreat” SKU at \$5K/exec is straightforward to underwrite from this channel. C12 alone is roughly a \$50M subscription channel with thousands of executives who already buy peer-led Christian experiences.

Demand signals across the men’s ministry market

- Only ~10% of churches have an active men’s ministry; **<1% of churchgoing men participate in any ongoing men’s program** — but **95% of men who attend a conference report a life-changing decision**. That gap between supply and reported impact is the strongest demand signal in the dataset.
- No Regrets Men’s Conference (Elmbrook Church, WI) draws 3,000+ men annually.
- Iron Sharpens Iron has delivered 485+ one-day conferences through 2024.
- Promise Keepers: peaked in the mid-1990s with 1M+ men/year at stadium events, collapsed late-1990s after removing admission fees (a structural lesson — see Section 8). Multiple relaunch attempts, current 2024 iteration at Oral Roberts University.
- Wellness retreat market broadly: **\$248B in 2025, projected \$399B by 2030 (9.9% CAGR)**.
- Churches & Religious Organizations industry: \$245.8B in 2024, growing 7.8% annually.

The competitive map — every observed operator sits in one of three quadrants

Quadrant	Examples	Gap relative to Pintail
Real hunt / no curriculum	Pine Hill, Rio Piedra, Honey Brake, Joshua Creek, Habitat Flats	Faith branding occasional, no structured discipleship
Real curriculum / no hunt	Wild at Heart, Promise Keepers, Iron Sharpens Iron, C12, Halftime	Conference/camp format, not real adventure
Some hunt / some faith / low production	Refreshed Soul, FCA Outdoors, FCS Plus, COFA, Ironman, Legacy	Volunteer-led, donor-subsidized, not premium

Nobody owns the upper-right: premium hunting infrastructure + intentional faith curriculum + production value + paid model. That is Pintail’s quadrant, and it is undefended.

4. The Corporate / Executive Retreat Market — A Second, Larger Demand Channel

Market size and growth

- Global corporate retreats: **\$31.8B in 2024 → \$73.7B by 2034**, 9.1% CAGR. North America dominates; tech, finance, healthcare are the most active buyers.
- Broader corporate events: ~\$325B in 2023 → ~\$600B by 2029 (10.6% CAGR). U.S. corporate event spend approaching \$30B/year.
- AMEX GBT 2025 Global M&E Forecast: 66% of meeting pros expect budgets to grow in 2025; in-person dominates.
- **Planners sourcing unique/experiential venues jumped from 17% in 2023 to 49% in 2025 — a 3x increase in two years.** This is the single most direct tailwind for Pintail’s model.
- 70% of planners expect in-person meeting volume to rise up to 20% in 2026; 85% are optimistic about the industry.

Per-person benchmarks

Tier	Per person, 2–3 days	Source
Standard hotel-ballroom offsite	\$2,000–\$4,000	BoomPop / Prospeo
Executive Sales Kickoff (SKO)	\$2,500–\$5,500, median ~\$3,144	Offsite Substack, Prospeo
“Realistic” benchmark per The Offsite Co.	\$750–\$850 per person per night + flights	The Offsite Co.
Premium experiential (Blackberry Farm)	\$7,800/person all-in for 3 nights (real-world reports)	Blackberry Farm
Ranch at Rock Creek (MT)	\$1,800–\$2,600/room/night + 20% ranch fee all-in	Ranch at Rock Creek
Hunting-branded exec trip (Joshua Creek, TX)	\$3,750–\$4,250/shooter for 2N/2D	Joshua Creek
Pine Hill Plantation 3-day quail event	\$6,800/person	Pine Hill

Tier	Per person, 2–3 days	Source
Orvis Endorsed trips	\$3,328 (Belize) to \$9,030 (Iceland) to \$7,000 (Montana)	Orvis
IRF Incentive Travel — top performers	Top performers spend ~\$3,000 more per top sales trip than peers (60–80% premium per participant)	IRF 2025

The sweet spot

Stacking the data, **a curated faith-based hunting retreat at \$4,500–\$8,000/attendee for 3 days, all-in** sits squarely between the Joshua Creek hunting-package floor and the Blackberry Farm/Pine Hill/Rock Creek ceiling. It is a defensible “premium-but-not-ultra-luxury” tier with proven willingness to pay across multiple operator categories.

Buying behavior

- Average B2B deal involves **6.8 stakeholders** (up from 5.4 in 2020); enterprise involves 11–13.
- Decision-makers for retreats: CEO/COO (final say on premium/strategic), Head of Sales/CRO (sole owner of SKO budgets), Head of HR/CPO (engagement/culture/leadership trips), EA/Chief of Staff (logistics gatekeeper, often the first call), CFO (sign-off above ~\$50K).
- Sales cycle by deal size: SMB <\$15K = 14–30 days; mid-market \$15–50K = 30–60 days; \$100K+ = 90–180 days; \$250K+ = 180–365 days.
- **For Pintail’s expected deal sizes (\$50K–\$160K, or 8–20 attendees × \$5K–\$8K), expect a 60–120 day sales cycle with a 2–4 stakeholder buying committee.**

HNW family adventure benchmarks

For the father-son / family product line:

- **Abercrombie & Kent family adventures:** start ~\$3,500/person; range to \$13,795+ for Spain/Portugal small-group; private jet journeys \$167,950/person.
- **Trufflepig** — white-glove bespoke for HNW travelers, custom pricing.
- **Backroads** family active trips: \$4,000–\$8,000/person.
- **Tauck** family river/safari trips: \$8,000–\$15,000/person/week.

HNW father-son hunting/fishing at \$8,000-\$15,000 per pair sits comfortably within established family-adventure ranges.

The “luxury + meaning” macro tailwind

- Wellness travel market: **\$945B (2024) → \$1.03T (2025) → \$1.3T by 2028.**
- International wellness tourists spend **41% more per trip**; domestic wellness travelers spend **175% more** than average.
- U.S./Middle East/Asia travelers willing to pay **30%+ more** for premium experiential.
- Esalen, Modern Elder Academy, Wim Hof, Robbins UPW all charge **\$2,500-\$10,000+** for 4-7 day transformational experiences — directly validating the price-anchor.

Pintail is the *masculine analog* of transformational-wellness. That category commands a 30-40% premium over equivalent non-transformational experiences.

Why this matters for Pintail

The corporate channel is bigger than the faith-only consumer channel and is growing 9.1% CAGR. The macro tailwinds are stacked (experiential venue sourcing 3x'd in two years, corporate retreat spending up, in-person rebounding, wellness/transformational at all-time highs). And Pintail rides three converging tailwinds simultaneously — corporate retreat growth, experiential travel shift, and faith-tech category validation — that few competitors get to ride at once.

5. The Software / Platform Question — Build vs. Buy

Recapping the founder's vision: an all-in-one CRM + ERP + branded portal where (a) Pintail manages trips/clients/vendors/logistics internally, (b) clients see itineraries and trip info and get notifications, (c) vendors get advertised inside the portal as a partnership perk. Payments/invoicing can stay external.

What hunting outfitters use today

Vertical players include **LodgeRunner** (\$100-\$300/mo, the incumbent for hunting lodges since 2007, strong on guide assignment and license tracking), **Mallard Bay GuideTech** (mobile-first, QuickBooks sync, marketplace lead-gen), **Krytter** (commission-only), **HuntDocs** (waivers + tracking), **Vally** (modern UI), and a handful of smaller niche tools (RecHub, Outfitter Pro Online, Reservit). Generalist booking platforms widely used by guided outfitters include **Resmark Systems** (\$15-\$95/mo

+ 2.5–3.5%, ~\$2B+ outfitter bookings powered to date) and **FareHarbor** (no monthly fee, 6–8% booking fee passed to customer, plus 2% OTA surcharge).

Critical gap: **none of these have a client-facing branded mobile/portal experience**. The hunting vertical’s tools are internal ops tools. The premium client experience layer doesn’t exist in-vertical.

What retreat/group-experience operators use

WeTravel is the closest off-the-shelf fit for the *client-facing portion* of Pintail’s vision — multi-day trip payments, branded itineraries, group communication, e-signatures, auto-billing. 2.9% CC fee (3.9% AMEX), free US bank-transfer collection, free payouts, no required subscription on the basic tier. Purpose-built for retreat operators. **Retreat Guru** is its competitor on the wellness side. **TrovaTrip** runs a 15–20% marketplace cut but is for influencer-led trips, not white-label.

What boutique tour operators use

Tourwriter describes itself as “the OS for boutique tour operators and DMCs who craft bespoke multi-day itineraries” — closest philosophical match for Pintail’s craft-over-volume profile. Pairs with **Axus Travel App** for branded mobile client experiences. **Bókun** (Tripadvisor/Viator-owned) at \$49/mo + 1–1.5% is the best Viator/Tripadvisor channel manager but Pintail won’t sell via OTAs.

Build vs. buy economics

Industry benchmarks for custom CRM development in 2025:

- **MVP CRM:** \$15,000–\$40,000, 2–4 months
- **Basic CRM for small team:** \$30,000–\$60,000
- **Full custom CRM:** \$60,000–\$150,000+
- **Per-integration cost:** \$1,500–\$8,000 each
- US developer rates \$100–\$180/hour; offshore \$20–\$80/hour

Stack options ranked for Pintail’s profile:

Stack	Fit	MVP cost	Maintenance
Next.js + Supabase + Vercel	Modern, brand-flexible, real-time, AI-ready	\$15–40K with contractor; 2–4 weeks experienced dev	\$25–150/mo infra + occasional dev hours
Bubble	No-code, faster iteration but hard to migrate off	\$10–25K agency or DIY	\$29–129/mo

Stack	Fit	MVP cost	Maintenance
Airtable + Softr	Quickest path; database in Airtable, portal in Softr	\$5-15K, 2-6 weeks	\$24-165/mo combined
Retool	Internal tool excellence, weaker public portals	\$5-15K admin-only	\$10-50/user/mo
FlutterFlow	Mobile-first if needed early	\$15-35K	\$30-70/mo

Faith-tech precedent for moat-building

VC funding for faith-based apps has tripled since 2015. **Subsplash** provides white-label apps for ministries. **Ministry Brands** has rolled up 30+ FaithTech companies, 95K+ orgs, \$100M+ EBITDA. **REI Adventures**, **SoulCycle**, **Equinox**, and **Peloton** all built proprietary booking/community apps that became material parts of brand identity. Faith-aligned, branded, premium-positioned platforms can become real moats.

The recommendation: stage the buy → build journey

Year 1 (now → ~12 trips): BUY a stitched stack. Don't invest in custom development before workflows stabilize. Recommended Year-1 stack (~\$200-\$400/mo all-in):

- **WeTravel** as the client-facing payment + branded itinerary + group communication layer (2.9% fee, covers ~60% of the client portal vision)
- **HubSpot Free or Pipedrive Essential** (\$0-\$14/user/mo) as the CRM for prospects, repeat clients, email sequences
- **Airtable + Softr** (\$24-\$80/mo) as the lightweight internal “ERP” — trips, vendors, gear, guide schedules, faith elements (devotionals, prayer requests), plus a vendor-facing portal page that satisfies the vendor-advertising perk on day one
- Loom/Notion for vendor onboarding
- QuickBooks for accounting

Total Year 1 software spend: **~\$4K**. Ships in 2-4 weeks of part-time configuration. Gives a branded client experience, a vendor portal, and a single source of truth.

Year 2+ (after 15-25 trips): EVALUATE the build trigger. Two decision triggers should drive the move to custom:

1. **WeTravel fees exceed ~\$20K/year** — at that point a \$40K custom build pays back in 2 years.
2. **Airtable hits its data-model ceiling** — when vendor-as-advertiser, faith content libraries, and repeat-client preference logic outgrow Airtable.

When triggered: BUILD on Next.js + Supabase. That stack is the modern default for branded client portals (real-time, mobile-PWA, full white-label); Supabase Auth + RLS handles multi-role (internal/vendor/client) natively; cost to MVP with a strong contractor is \$30-\$60K (6-10 weeks); ongoing infra \$50-\$200/mo. Pintail owns the IP — which matters for the faith-aligned positioning and vendor advertising differentiation.

Don't pick a hunting-vertical platform (LodgeRunner, Mallard Bay, Hunt-Docs). They're built for traditional outfitters, not curated faith retreats. Their client-facing UX is utilitarian, not branded — exactly the opposite of Pintail's positioning. None support vendor-as-advertiser. Migration off later is painful.

6. Pricing Strategy & Product Tiers

Pulling the data together, three product tiers are defensible from day one.

Tier 1 — Curated Corporate Retreat (the core)

- **Audience.** Faith-aligned executive teams (Christian-led companies, C12/Convene/YPO Christian members, family-business C-suites). 8-20 attendees per trip.
- **Format.** 3 days, all-inclusive, anchored at a top-tier partner lodge (Pine Hill, Rio Piedra, Joshua Creek, Habitat Flats).
- **Price.** **\$5,000-\$8,000 per attendee.**
- **Deal size.** \$40K-\$160K per engagement.
- **Sales cycle.** 60-120 days with a 2-4 stakeholder committee (CEO + CFO + EA/Chief of Staff).
- **Competitive anchors.** Above Joshua Creek's \$3,750-\$4,250 hunting floor; below Pine Hill's \$6,800 plus the Pintail premium; right alongside Blackberry Farm at \$7,800.

Tier 2 — Father-Son / Legacy Trip (the HNW family product)

- **Audience.** HNW fathers (HHI \$300K+) bringing sons (typically 12-25 years old) or daughters. 6-10 pairs per trip.
- **Format.** 3-day or 5-day, premium hunting + intentional rite-of-passage curriculum co-built with the father-in-law's theology background.

- **Price.** \$8,000-\$15,000 per pair for 3 days; \$15,000-\$25,000 per pair for 5-day flagship.
- **Competitive anchors.** Sits inside Abercrombie & Kent (\$3,500-\$13,795/person) and Tauck (\$8,000-\$15,000/person/week) ranges. Wild at Heart proves curriculum willingness-to-pay; nobody else combines premium hunting + father-son rite of passage + theological framing.

Tier 3 — Church Leadership / Board Retreat (the recurring relationship)

- **Audience.** Elder boards, major-donor circles, or top business-leader members from mid-to-large churches. 10-25 men.
- **Format.** 3 days, more curriculum-heavy than the corporate product, partner-lodge anchored.
- **Price.** \$3,000-\$5,000 per attendee.
- **Why narrower:** General church men's retreats are price-sensitive (\$200-\$400/person is the standard). The Pintail target is the *leadership / major-donor sub-segment within churches*, not the broad men's retreat market.

Tier 4 (Year 2+) — Annual Corporate Membership

A \$25K-\$50K annual corporate membership grants 2 retreats/year, off-season leadership coaching, and content access. Mirrors C12's recurring-revenue model and smooths Pintail's revenue away from pure event lumpiness.

Pricing-cohesion notes

- The 5-day flagship at \$10K-\$12K/person sits within the genre at Beretta Trident-tier lodges.
- Below ~\$5K/3 days Pintail dilutes brand and starts competing with mid-tier preserves.
- Sport-side benchmarks (Pine Hill, Habitat Flats, Joshua Creek) all live above \$3K/day all-in, giving Pintail no need to justify a *new* price band — just to occupy a clearly defined one with a differentiated experience.

7. The Whitespace Map

Synthesizing the five streams into one competitive picture:

Player / Category	Hunting depth	Curriculum depth	Production value	Pricing tier	Pintail overlap
Pine Hill, Rio Piedra, SouthWind, Habitat Flats	High	Low/none	High	\$1K- \$2K/day	Partner, not compete
Honey Brake, Heaven Scent, Woods-N- Water	Med-high	Low (faith branding only)	Med	\$500- \$650/day	Adjacent — Pintail premium leapfrogs them
Wild at Heart	None	High	Low (mountain teaching retreats)	\$260/3 nights	Cultural proof; not competitor
Promise Keepers, Iron Sharpens Iron	None	Med	Low (conference)	\$30- \$60/day	Cultural validation only
Refreshed Soul, FCA Outdoors, Ironman	Med	Med	Low (donor- funded)	Free-\$1K	Subsidized — different market
C12, Convene, Halftime, Pinnacle	None	High	Med (peer advisory)	\$6K/yr to \$14K/yr	Channel partner
Joshua Creek, Brush Creek, Rock Creek corporate	High	None	High	\$4K- \$10K/3 days	Partner / direct comp for corporate

Player / Category	Hunting depth	Curriculum depth	Production value	Pricing tier	Pintail overlap
Pintail Ex- periences (pro- posed)	High (partner network)	High (theology- backed curricu- lum)	High	\$5K- \$8K/3 days	—

The whitespace is a single empty cell: high hunting + high curriculum + high production + premium price + paid model. Pintail is uniquely positioned to fill it.

8. Strategic Implications & Recommendations

Pulling everything together into the takeaways the founders should internalize before writing the business plan.

1. **The whitespace is real and undefended.** Every adjacent player addresses one or two of the three dimensions (hunting / curriculum / production). None addresses all three at a premium price point. Pintail does not need to invent a category — it needs to occupy an unoccupied corner of an existing matrix.
2. **The market is large enough.** 14.4M U.S. hunters, ~1.4-2.2M HHI \$150K+, a \$31.8B corporate retreats market growing 9.1% CAGR, and \$1T+ in wellness/transformational travel growing 7-10%. Capturing 0.05-0.5% of any of these is a real business.
3. **Pricing power is already validated by adjacent operators.** Pine Hill at \$6,800 for 3 days, Habitat Flats at \$2,100 for 3 days, Joshua Creek at \$3,750-\$4,250 for 2 days, Halftime at \$6,000 for a 12-month fellowship, Esalen at \$2,500-\$10,000 for transformational weeks. **Anchor at \$5K-\$8K/3 days; flagship at \$10K-\$12K/5 days; family pair at \$8K-\$15K. Don't go below \$5K — it dilutes brand.**
4. **For-profit LLC, not 501(c)(3) (with a sister non-profit for scholarship seats).** Donor-supported ministries (Refreshed Soul, FCA, FCS, Ironman) cap at “free or near-free” and compete on access. Premium positioning requires for-profit clarity. The standard hybrid is a for-profit LLC running the core business + a sister 501(c)(3) running pastor/scholarship seats subsidized by donor underwriting. Best of both worlds.
5. **The father-in-law's credentials are a moat.** Most outdoor ministries are run by hunters who got saved, not credentialed theologians. A Master's in Theol-

ogy + PhD anchors curriculum legitimacy in a market where competitors offer devotional pamphlets. **Treat the curriculum as branded IP from day one** — copyright it, name it, version it, build a content library around it.

6. **Anchor first partnerships in two geographies.** Red Hills quail: Rio Piedra, Pine Hill, SouthWind, Riverview (all Orvis-Endorsed / Trident-class). Stuttgart-Missouri Golden Triangle duck: Habitat Flats, Five Oaks, Black Dog. Add Joshua Creek (TX) and Pursell Farms (AL) for geographic and price-point diversity. Pintail's curator model — quail in winter, dove in fall, redfish/turkey in spring, across multiple properties — is something single-property lodges literally cannot match.
7. **Don't own the lodge.** The lodge layer is fragmented, mom-and-pop, and partner-friendly. Land economics in the Red Hills make new entrants prohibitive. Asset-light scales faster, preserves margin, and avoids the failure mode that consumed Wynfield Plantation.
8. **Sell through the Christian CEO channel.** C12 (4,300 members), Convene, YPO Christian forums, Halftime Institute, Pinnacle Forum — these networks already aggregate the buyers Pintail wants and already charge them for transformational programming. A Pintail "Chapter Annual Retreat" SKU sold into C12/Convene at \$5K-\$8K/exec is a fast-growth wedge that bypasses cold sales.
9. **Lead with two corporate ICPs, not one.** (a) Faith-aligned executive teams of 8-20 (Christian-led companies, family-business C-suites). (b) Premium SKO/leadership offsites at faith-friendly mid-sized companies (200-2,000 EE). The first won't budge on values; the second will pay premium for differentiation.
10. **Father-son / father-daughter is the most defensible consumer product.** Fathers in the Field, Discipleship Adventures, Primal Path validate demand; none operate at premium price or hunting depth. This is the "Wild at Heart for the next generation of fathers" lane — and it doubles as the most viral product (the dad becomes the lifelong advocate and brings the son in for repeat trips over 10+ years).
11. **Quail and waterfowl beat deer for the brand.** Deer hunting is solo, slow, and not group-bondable. Quail (covey rises, walking, shared dogs) and duck (blinds, shared experience, dawn) are inherently group-discipleship formats. Pintail's species choice is structurally correct for the curriculum thesis.
12. **Production value is the cheapest moat to build.** Existing ministries have weak websites, no film, no podcast. A polished brand film, professional shoots, and a serialized podcast featuring the father-in-law's teaching would create immediate category leadership at relatively low cost (\$20K-\$50K Year 1).
13. **Marketing channels with the highest signal:** Ducks Unlimited (678K mem-

bers) + Pheasants/Quail Forever (140K) banquet circuits; the MeatEater/Joe Rogan/Cam Hanes adjacent audience; C12/Convene member newsletters; faith-aligned Yellowstone/Yeti-customer overlap (CMS, Christianity Today). Lower-signal: paid social, generic outdoor publications.

14. **Conservation alignment is brand armor.** Position Pintail as a partner to DU/PF/Delta Waterfowl with a per-trip conservation donation. This neutralizes “rich guys shooting birds” criticism, deepens credibility with serious hunters, and unlocks co-marketing access with the largest organizations in the space.
15. **Don’t repeat Promise Keepers’ mistake.** When PK removed admission in pursuit of accessibility, the business collapsed. Premium pricing isn’t a barrier to mission — it filters audience, funds production quality, and avoids the donor-treadmill failure mode that has consumed multiple predecessors. **Hold the line on pricing.**
16. **Software: buy in Year 1, build in Year 2+.** WeTravel + HubSpot/Pipedrive + Airtable/Softy at ~\$4K/year. Don’t spend \$40K on custom development before workflows stabilize. The custom Next.js + Supabase build comes when (a) WeTravel fees exceed \$20K/year, or (b) the vendor-as-advertiser logic outgrows Airtable. Most likely Trip #15-25.
17. **Three KPIs from day one.** (a) Per-attendee revenue, (b) corporate repeat rate, (c) CEO-to-CEO referral velocity. Faith-based premium markets are tight, word-of-mouth driven, and built on a few hundred warm referrals — not paid acquisition. Track these obsessively from Trip #1.

Risks and cautions

- **Land/lodge access risk.** If 2-3 anchor lodges go private (Wynfield is the warning), Pintail needs depth on the bench. Sign letters of intent or 3-year MOUs with at least 5 anchor partners across two flyways before launching publicly.
- **Founder concentration risk.** The friend is the brand, the relationships, the curriculum co-author, and the operator. Plan for a #2 hire (operations or sales) by Trip #10.
- **Donor expectation creep.** Faith-aligned customers and corporate sponsors will push for charitable underwriting and “ministry” framing. Decide early which programs (pastor scholarship seats, youth trips) sit in the 501(c)(3) and which sit in the for-profit, and don’t let that line blur.
- **Seasonality cash crunch.** 60% of bookings fall Nov-Mar. Q2-Q3 cash discipline is essential. Use shoulder-season programming (corporate clays days, men’s-ministry summer weekends, dove in September) and Year-2 membership pre-pay to smooth.
- **Vendor advertising perception risk.** “Vendors advertised inside the portal”

is a real differentiator but must be curated — make it feel like a Garden & Gun editorial recommendation, not a billboard. Vendor inclusion = brand vouching.

9. Recommended Next Steps

In rough order of leverage:

1. **Founder + father-in-law alignment session.** Lock in the curriculum thesis: what specific transformation Pintail promises, in what scriptural and theological frame. Write a 2-page brand brief from that conversation.
 2. **Anchor partner outreach.** 30-minute intro calls with Rio Piedra, Pine Hill, SouthWind, Joshua Creek, Habitat Flats, Five Oaks. Goal: 5 letters of intent for the 2026-27 season at preferred-partner rates.
 3. **Financial model v0.** Spreadsheet that plugs in trip price, capacity (8-20 attendees), cost per attendee (lodge pass-through + curriculum + transport + branded gear + film + Pintail margin), and produces breakeven, monthly P&L, and 24-month runway projection at three volume scenarios (6 / 12 / 24 trips/year). Compare to the friend's current sales-job income to size the leap.
 4. **Mission / vision / values one-pager.** Draft from this brief, sharpen with founder, ready for friend to react.
 5. **Brand name + identity audit.** "Pintail Experiences" is good; verify trademark availability and domain options. Brand identity (logo, palette, type) at Year-1 should aim for "Yeti meets Garden & Gun meets a leather-bound seminary book."
 6. **Software stack stand-up.** WeTravel + Airtable/Softy in 2-4 weeks. Begin client/vendor data model that anticipates Year-2 custom build.
 7. **Channel pilot.** Approach C12 or Convene about a single chapter retreat as a pilot — discounted rate in exchange for case study rights, video footage, and testimonials.
 8. **Operating agreement starter outline.** Entity type (for-profit LLC + sister 501(c)(3) recommended), ownership, profit splits if partners, liability structure. Ready for a lawyer to formalize.
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This brief should be the second canonical document in the Pintail Experience folder, sitting alongside the original voice-chat background brief. As partnerships firm up, pricing tests run, and the financial model gets built, update this file rather than starting fresh elsewhere.